

DSAT Reading & Writing — Function (Underlined Portion)

25 Original Practice Questions | Easy · Medium · Hard

Q1.

[Easy]

Bioluminescence is most commonly found among marine organisms: 76 percent of known luminescent species inhabit ocean environments. This prevalence is thought to result from the unique selective pressures of the deep sea, where sunlight cannot penetrate and organisms must produce their own light to communicate, hunt, or evade predators.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It provides a statistic that supports the text's claim about the distribution of bioluminescence.
 - B) It introduces a counterargument to the main claim made in the text.
 - C) It describes a research methodology that scientists used to study luminescent species.
 - D) It presents a finding that the text ultimately calls into question.
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Q2.

[Easy]

Sociologist Marco Pellegrini has found that neighborhoods with community gardens report higher levels of social cohesion than those without. Residents in garden-equipped neighborhoods were 35 percent more likely to know their neighbors by name and 28 percent more likely to participate in local civic meetings. Pellegrini suggests that shared outdoor spaces create informal opportunities for interaction that strengthen community bonds.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It questions whether community gardens truly improve social cohesion.
 - B) It provides specific data that support the finding about social cohesion described in the preceding sentence.
 - C) It describes the methodology Pellegrini used to conduct his study.
 - D) It introduces a new claim unrelated to the text's discussion of community gardens.
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Q3.

[Easy]

The Library of Alexandria, founded in the third century BCE, was one of the largest repositories of knowledge in the ancient world. Scholars traveled from across the Mediterranean to study its collection, which reportedly housed hundreds of thousands of scrolls. The library's destruction, the causes and timing of which remain debated, represented an incalculable loss of accumulated learning.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It presents evidence that the Library of Alexandria was smaller than commonly believed.
 - B) It elaborates on the library's significance by describing its scale and the scholarly activity it attracted.
 - C) It identifies the specific cause of the library's destruction.
 - D) It argues that modern libraries are modeled on the Library of Alexandria.
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Q4.

[Easy]

Many people assume that chameleons change color primarily to blend in with their surroundings, but research by herpetologist Ana Reyes has shown that color change is more commonly triggered by social signals and temperature regulation. Reyes found that chameleons display their most vivid colors during territorial disputes and courtship, not when attempting to hide from predators.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes a conclusion that Reyes's research confirmed.
 - B) It provides the main argument that the text defends throughout.
 - C) It presents a widely held assumption that the text goes on to challenge with research findings.
 - D) It introduces the methodology Reyes used to study chameleon behavior.
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Q5.

[Easy]

The following text is from Priya Desai's 2017 novel *The Orchard Gate*. Meera is reflecting on her childhood home. The house had been painted three times since she left, each coat a shade lighter than the last, as though the building itself were slowly forgetting its original color. Meera stood at the gate, uncertain whether to knock. The woman who answered would not be her mother, and the kitchen would smell of someone else's cooking.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It provides practical information about the maintenance history of the property.
 - B) It indicates that Meera disapproves of the new owners' taste in color.
 - C) It establishes that the house is in poor physical condition.
 - D) It uses the house's changing appearance to suggest the passage of time and the fading of the past.
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Q6.

[Easy]

Researchers studying memory consolidation have long known that sleep plays a role in transferring information from short-term to long-term memory. In a 2021 experiment, participants who slept for eight hours after learning a list of vocabulary words recalled 40 percent more words the following day than participants who remained awake. These findings support the broader hypothesis that sleep-dependent neural processes are critical for durable learning.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes an experimental result that supports the broader claim about sleep and memory presented in the text.
 - B) It introduces a finding that contradicts the established view of memory consolidation.
 - C) It explains the neural mechanism by which sleep enhances memory.
 - D) It provides the historical context in which sleep research began.
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Q7.

[Easy]

Urban sociologist Claudia Ferreira argues that public transportation systems should be evaluated not just by ridership numbers but by accessibility metrics such as the percentage of jobs reachable within a 45-minute commute. By this measure, cities like Houston, where most employment centers are accessible only by car, perform poorly despite having extensive bus networks. Ferreira contends that ridership alone can mask deep inequities in transportation access.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It provides an example that illustrates Ferreira's argument about the limitations of ridership-based evaluation.
 - B) It presents evidence that contradicts Ferreira's proposed accessibility metric.
 - C) It describes the historical development of Houston's public transit system.
 - D) It argues that Houston has the best public transportation system in the United States.
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Q8.

[Medium]

Ecologist Soren Lindqvist studies the recovery of forests after volcanic eruptions. Conventional ecological theory predicts that pioneer species—fast-growing plants that tolerate poor soils—should be the first to colonize barren volcanic terrain. Lindqvist's fieldwork on a recently erupted island in the Pacific, however, revealed that slow-growing mosses and lichens established themselves first, creating a thin soil layer that pioneer species subsequently exploited. This finding suggests that the standard model of ecological succession may need revision for volcanic landscapes.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It summarizes Lindqvist's main finding from his fieldwork on a volcanic island.
 - B) It describes a methodology that Lindqvist's study replicated from earlier ecological research.
 - C) It provides background information about volcanic eruptions and their effects on plant life.
 - D) It presents a prediction from established theory that the text goes on to complicate with contrasting evidence.
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Q9.

[Medium]

The following text is from Luca Bianchi's 2020 short story 'The Glassblower's Apprentice.' The master never praised a piece directly. If the vase held water without leaking and caught the light at the angle he wanted, he would simply nod and move to the next task. It was the absence of correction, not the presence of approval, that told the apprentice he had succeeded. Over time, the apprentice learned to read these silences the way a sailor reads calm seas—not as emptiness, but as a sign that nothing was wrong.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It suggests that the master was uninterested in the quality of the apprentice's work.
 - B) It introduces a conflict between the master and the apprentice that is resolved later in the text.
 - C) It clarifies the unconventional way the master communicated approval, which the subsequent comparison elaborates.
 - D) It provides a physical description of the master's workshop.
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Q10.

[Medium]

Psychologist Anya Morozova examined the effect of background music on task performance. Her study found that participants completed spatial reasoning tasks faster when listening to instrumental music at moderate volume than when working in silence. Participants who listened to music with lyrics, however, performed worse than both the silence and instrumental groups. Morozova suggests that lyrics compete for the same cognitive resources used in spatial reasoning, creating interference that instrumental music does not.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It introduces a contrasting finding that helps distinguish between the effects of different types of music on task performance.
 - B) It provides the main conclusion of Morozova's study.
 - C) It describes the methodology Morozova used to measure task performance.
 - D) It presents an exception to a general rule that Morozova considers insignificant.
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Q11.

[Medium]

The axolotl, a salamander native to lakes near Mexico City, can regenerate entire limbs, portions of its heart, and even sections of its spinal cord. Most vertebrates lose the capacity for significant tissue regeneration early in development, retaining only limited wound-healing abilities as adults. Biologist Carmen Vega has identified a set of genes in axolotls that remain active throughout their lives but are silenced in other vertebrates shortly after birth, a discovery that may explain the axolotl's exceptional regenerative powers.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes a finding that Vega's research has recently disproven.
 - B) It explains the genetic mechanism behind the axolotl's regeneration.
 - C) It provides evidence that regeneration is common across all vertebrate species.
 - D) It establishes a general norm among vertebrates that highlights the axolotl's unusual regenerative ability.
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Q12.

[Medium]

Archaeologist Lucia Torres discovered a cache of obsidian tools at a site in southern Chile dated to approximately 14,000 years ago. The nearest known obsidian source is located over 300 kilometers to the north, in a volcanic region of the Andes. Torres argues that the tools' presence at the site constitutes evidence of long-distance trade networks among early South American populations, a conclusion that challenges the view that such networks developed only after the advent of agriculture.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes the geological process by which obsidian is formed in volcanic regions.
 - B) It provides geographic evidence that supports Torres's claim about the existence of long-distance trade.
 - C) It introduces an alternative explanation for the presence of obsidian tools at the site.
 - D) It questions the accuracy of the dating methods used to determine the age of the tools.
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Q13.

[Medium]

Plant biologist Rena Okonkwo studies how trees allocate resources between growth and defense. In nutrient-rich environments, trees tend to invest heavily in rapid vertical growth, producing thinner bark and fewer chemical defenses against herbivores. Okonkwo's experiments showed that when she artificially reduced soil nutrients, the same tree species shifted resources toward thicker bark and higher concentrations of defensive compounds, suggesting a flexible trade-off mechanism rather than a fixed strategy.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes a baseline pattern of resource allocation that the text contrasts with the results of Okonkwo's experiments.
 - B) It presents the central finding of Okonkwo's experimental research.
 - C) It challenges the prevailing scientific understanding of how trees allocate resources.
 - D) It provides an example of a tree species that does not follow normal growth patterns.
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Q14.

[Medium]

Economist Tadashi Yamamoto has studied the effect of remote work on urban commercial real estate. He found that office vacancy rates in central business districts rose significantly between 2020 and 2023. Some analysts predicted that these vacancies would trigger a collapse in commercial property values. Yamamoto's data tell a more nuanced story: while mid-tier office buildings did lose value, premium properties with modern amenities maintained or even increased their rents, as companies competed for high-quality spaces to attract employees back to the office.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes a finding that Yamamoto's research fully supports.
 - B) It introduces the methodology Yamamoto used to collect his data.
 - C) It provides historical context about the commercial real estate market before 2020.
 - D) It presents a prediction that the text then qualifies by showing a more complex reality.
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Q15.

[Medium]

The following text is from Aisha Kamara's 2019 essay collection *Maps Without Borders*. My mother's English was grammatically imperfect but emotionally precise. She could describe a feeling in four words that would take me a paragraph to approximate. 'The loneliness of airports,' she once said, and I knew exactly what she meant—not the solitude of being alone, but the particular ache of being surrounded by people who are all going somewhere else. I spent years in graduate school learning to write, and she still said more with less.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It provides a specific example that illustrates the claim in the preceding sentences about the mother's linguistic precision.
 - B) It introduces a disagreement between the speaker and the mother about the meaning of loneliness.
 - C) It describes the speaker's experience of traveling through airports as a child.
 - D) It presents a critique of the graduate school education the speaker received.
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Q16.

[Medium]

Marine biologist Kai Nakamura has proposed that the bright coloration of many reef fish serves not only as a warning to predators but also as a form of species recognition in the visually complex reef environment. In controlled tank experiments, fish consistently chose to associate with conspecifics (members of the same species) over similarly sized fish of different species, even when the only distinguishing feature was color pattern. Nakamura concludes that coloration functions as a social signal at least as much as a defensive one.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It presents a finding that undermines Nakamura's broader argument about reef fish coloration.
 - B) It explains the evolutionary origin of coloration in reef fish.
 - C) It describes experimental evidence that supports the hypothesis about color as a species-recognition signal.
 - D) It compares the behavior of reef fish with that of freshwater fish.
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Q17.

[Medium]

During the Industrial Revolution, child labor was widespread in British textile mills. Reformer Robert Owen, who owned several mills himself, argued that educating child workers rather than exploiting them would ultimately increase productivity by producing a healthier, more skilled workforce. Owen's model, implemented at his New Lanark mill in Scotland, combined reduced working hours for children with on-site schooling, demonstrating that humane labor practices and commercial success were not mutually exclusive.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes the typical practices of mill owners during the Industrial Revolution.
 - B) It introduces Owen's argument that humane treatment of child workers served both moral and economic purposes, which the text then supports with a specific example.
 - C) It presents a criticism of Owen's approach to labor reform.
 - D) It provides statistical evidence about the productivity of child workers in British mills.
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Q18.

[Hard]

Neurobiologist Fatou Sow has investigated how the brain processes conflicting sensory information. In everyday perception, the brain seamlessly integrates signals from multiple senses—sight, sound, touch—to construct a coherent experience of the environment. Sow's experiments, however, introduced systematic mismatches between visual and auditory stimuli and found that the brain does not simply average the conflicting signals but instead assigns dominance to whichever sense has historically been more reliable for the type of task at hand. This finding challenges earlier models that treated sensory integration as a simple weighted average.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It summarizes the main conclusion of Sow's research.
 - B) It presents a claim that Sow's experiments were designed to confirm.
 - C) It provides background on the technology Sow used to measure brain activity.
 - D) It describes the normal process of sensory integration that Sow's experiments then reveal to be more complex than previously understood.
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Q19.

[Hard]

The following text is from Elif Bozkurt's 2021 novel *The Thread and the Needle*. The tailor's shop had no sign. Locals knew where it was; strangers were not expected. Inside, bolts of fabric lined the walls from floor to ceiling, arranged not by color or pattern but by the occasion for which each cloth was typically used—mourning silks beside wedding brocades, baptismal cottons next to burial linens. This arrangement struck visitors as morbid, but the tailor saw it as honest: life's ceremonies, he believed, were not as separate as people liked to pretend.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes the unusual organization of the shop, which the subsequent sentences interpret as reflecting the tailor's philosophy.
 - B) It provides evidence that the tailor's business is financially unsuccessful.
 - C) It contrasts the tailor's organizational system with those used by other shopkeepers.
 - D) It introduces a character who will later challenge the tailor's beliefs about life's ceremonies.
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Q20.

[Hard]

Climate scientist Ingrid Haugen has studied the effects of permafrost thaw on Arctic carbon cycling. As permafrost melts, organic matter that has been frozen for millennia becomes available to soil microbes, which decompose it and release carbon dioxide and methane into the atmosphere. Some researchers have estimated that permafrost regions store nearly twice as much carbon as the entire atmosphere currently contains. Haugen's modeling work, however, suggests that the rate of release will depend critically on local hydrology: waterlogged soils tend to produce methane, a more potent greenhouse gas, while drier soils release carbon dioxide, which is less potent but longer-lived.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It presents a finding that Haugen's modeling work has contradicted.
 - B) It describes the methodology researchers used to measure permafrost carbon stores.
 - C) It conveys the scale of the carbon stored in permafrost, underscoring the potential significance of the process described in the surrounding text.
 - D) It introduces an alternative hypothesis about the origin of atmospheric carbon that the text evaluates.
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Q21.

[Hard]

Political theorist Kwesi Mensah has examined how colonial-era legal frameworks continue to shape property rights in postcolonial nations. In many formerly colonized countries, customary land tenure systems—in which communities rather than individuals held rights to land—were supplanted by colonial property laws that recognized only individual ownership documented through formal titles. Mensah argues that this legacy creates ongoing conflicts between communities claiming ancestral rights and governments enforcing title-based ownership, and he calls for hybrid legal frameworks that recognize both systems.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It presents Mensah's proposed solution to the property rights conflicts described in the text.
 - B) It describes the historical shift in property law that Mensah identifies as the root cause of the conflicts discussed in the rest of the text.
 - C) It provides evidence that customary land tenure systems were ineffective before colonization.
 - D) It introduces a counterargument to Mensah's claim about the impact of colonial legal frameworks.
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Q22.

[Hard]

Paleontologist Jia Wei has challenged the long-held view that the mass extinction at the end of the Cretaceous period was caused solely by a meteorite impact. Geological evidence shows that massive volcanic eruptions in what is now India—known as the Deccan Traps—began approximately 250,000 years before the impact event and continued for another 500,000 years afterward. Wei argues that these eruptions destabilized global climate before the impact and continued to suppress recovery afterward, meaning that the extinction resulted from the combined effects of volcanism and impact rather than either factor alone.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It presents a timeline that disproves the theory that volcanic eruptions contributed to the extinction.
 - B) It describes the methods geologists used to date the Deccan Traps eruptions.
 - C) It introduces a finding that Wei considers irrelevant to the extinction debate.
 - D) It provides geological evidence that supports Wei's argument for a multi-causal explanation of the extinction.
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Q23.

[Hard]

The following text is from Rosa Figueroa's 2022 novel *The Unfinished Garden*. The architect returned to the site every morning, though the client had abandoned the project months ago. She measured angles that would never become walls, sketched rooms no one would inhabit. Her colleagues, all employed on paying commissions, regarded her visits as an eccentricity—charming at first, then worrisome. But the architect understood something they did not: that the value of a design was not determined by whether it was built.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It provides evidence that the architect's professional reputation has been damaged.
 - B) It establishes the perspective of the architect's colleagues, which the text then contrasts with the architect's own belief.
 - C) It explains why the client abandoned the construction project.
 - D) It describes a disagreement about architectural style between the architect and her colleagues.
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Q24.

[Hard]

Immunologist Dario Rossi has investigated why certain vaccines produce long-lasting immunity while others require periodic boosters. The prevailing explanation holds that vaccine durability depends primarily on the persistence of memory B cells, which can rapidly produce antibodies when re-exposed to a pathogen. Rossi's research, however, suggests that the structural stability of the antigen used in the vaccine also plays a critical role: antigens that maintain their shape over time continue to stimulate the immune system at low levels, effectively acting as an ongoing booster. This finding has implications for the design of future vaccines.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes the main conclusion of Rossi's research.
 - B) It introduces a hypothesis that Rossi's experiments have definitively disproven.
 - C) It presents the conventional explanation for vaccine durability that the text then supplements with Rossi's additional finding.
 - D) It explains the chemical structure of the antigens used in vaccines.
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Q25.

[Hard]

Behavioral researcher Nadia Petrov has studied how framing affects charitable giving. Prior research had established that people donate more when presented with a single identifiable victim (such as a named child in need) than when given statistical summaries of large-scale suffering—a phenomenon known as the 'identifiable victim effect.' Petrov's experiments added a layer of complexity: she found that donors who were first shown a statistical overview and then introduced to an individual case gave less than donors who encountered the individual case alone. Petrov hypothesizes that statistical framing activates analytical thinking, which dampens the emotional response that drives generosity toward identifiable victims.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It describes the main finding of Petrov's own experiments.
 - B) It introduces a criticism of the methodology used in earlier studies of charitable giving.
 - C) It establishes a previously documented phenomenon that Petrov's research then builds upon and complicates.
 - D) It provides a definition of a concept that the text ultimately rejects as inaccurate.
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